

FSWP vs CEC vs FSTP: The Eligibility Comparison Table

The three Express Entry programs side by side - work experience, language minimums, education, funds, and the requirement that usually decides which door you enter through.

All three programs feed the same Express Entry pool and use the same CRS score once you are in. Eligibility is what differs - and it is assessed per program, so strengthening one requirement (language, for instance) can open a second program and with it a second set of draw types.

The comparison

Requirement	Federal Skilled Worker	Canadian Experience Class	Federal Skilled Trades
Skilled work experience	1 year continuous (1,560 h) in the last 10 years	1 year (1,560 h) in the last 3 years	2 years (3,120 h) in the last 5 years
Where the experience counts	Canada or abroad	Canada only	Canada or abroad
Occupation type	TEER 0, 1, 2 or 3 (one NOC, continuous)	TEER 0, 1, 2 or 3	Skilled trade: NOC Major Group 72 (excl. 726), 73, 82, 83, 92 or 93 (excl. 932)
Language minimum	CLB/NCLC 7 in all four abilities	CLB/NCLC 7 (TEER 0/1 job) or CLB/NCLC 5 (TEER 2/3 job)	CLB/NCLC 5 speaking + listening; CLB/NCLC 4 reading + writing
Education	Secondary minimum; foreign credential needs an ECA	No education requirement	No education requirement
Job offer / certificate	Not required	Not required	1-year full-time job offer OR provincial/territorial/federal certificate of qualification in the trade
Proof of funds	Required, unless legally working in Canada with a valid job offer	Not required	Required, unless legally working in Canada with a valid job offer
Extra gate	67/100 on the six selection factors	None	None

Part-time counts everywhere at the same total-hours arithmetic: e.g. 15 hours/week for 24 months equals 1 year full-time (1,560 hours). Volunteer work and unpaid internships never count - experience must have been paid in wages or commission.

How to read this strategically

- **One year in Canada changes everything** - CEC removes the education requirement, the proof-of-funds requirement, and the 67-point grid in one move, and CEC-only draws are a recurring draw type.
- **FSWP is the only door that opens from abroad without a job offer** - but it is also the only program with the 67-point selection grid; check it before investing in anything else.
- **FSTP's language bar is the lowest** (CLB 5/4) - but it trades that for the hardest practical gate: a 1-year job offer or a Canadian certificate of qualification. If the province where you plan to live does not certify your trade, a job offer is the only route.
- **Eligible for more than one program?** You enter the same pool with the same CRS either way - what changes is which program-specific draws can reach you.

Sources

Every rule and figure in this document was verified against the following official pages on 19 July 2026:

- canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/immigrate-canada/express-entry/who-can-apply/federal-s-killed-workers.html
- canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/immigrate-canada/express-entry/who-can-apply/canadian-experience-class.html
- canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/immigrate-canada/express-entry/who-can-apply/federal-s-killed-trades.html
- canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/immigrate-canada/express-entry/documents/language-test.html

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